

8 English Lines Hotel Staff Use With Angry Guests

Eight phrases for the moment a guest complaint becomes serious. These are not vocabulary words. They are the exact sentences a senior front desk professional uses, in the order they use them.

What you will be able to do

By the end of this page.

1. Identify which of two replies a senior professional would give, and say why
2. Explain why apologising twice makes an angry guest angrier, not calmer
3. Produce all eight lines from the situation alone, without reading them
4. Evaluate your own wording mid-complaint and change it before the guest asks for your manager

BEFORE YOU START

"I know what to say when a guest is furious and asks for my manager."

Nobody sees this but you. It is stored on this device.

Before you read anything

One shift, eight decisions. You have not been taught these yet — that is the point. Commit to an answer, then find out.



It is eleven at night. A guest is at your desk holding a confirmation email for a room that was given away four hours ago, and the hotel is full. He has been travelling since six this morning, and he has just asked you twice whether you understand what you have done to his evening.

1. Which one does a senior professional say?

Why the other one lands badly. You are agreeing with the guest, not only saying sorry. Saying sorry again and again can sound weak. When you agree, the guest feels you are on their side.

SAY IT That should not have happened.

That should not have happened, and I understand why you are upset.

2. Which one does a senior professional say?

Why the other one lands badly. The important words are right now. I will try sounds like no. When you say right now, the guest knows you have already started, so they stop repeating themselves.

SAY IT Let me see what I can do right now.

Let me see what I can do right now, Mister Adeyemi.

3. Which one does a senior professional say?

Why the other one lands badly. You say who will fix it, and when. I am going to is a promise. I will try is not. Guests ask for a manager when nobody takes the job, so this sentence keeps it with you.

SAY IT I am going to fix this for you tonight.

I am going to fix this for you tonight. Give me two minutes.

4. Which one does a senior professional say?

Why the other one lands badly. Now you move from the problem to the answer. If you begin with unfortunately, the guest waits for bad news. If you begin with here is, they listen.

SAY IT Here is what I can offer you.

Here is what I can offer you, and please tell me if it does not work.

5. Which one does a senior professional say?

Why the other one lands badly. Say it is done, not that it might happen. A question sounds like you are not sure. I have moved you tells the guest the problem is already finished.

SAY IT I have moved you to a room on the executive floor.

I have moved you to a room on the executive floor at no extra charge.

6. Which one does a senior professional say?

Why the other one lands badly. Do not blame the computer. It may be true, but it does not help. The guest wants a person, not a reason. This sentence usually stops a guest asking for a manager.

SAY IT I will take personal responsibility for this.

I will take personal responsibility for this until you are settled.

7. Which one does a senior professional say?

Why the other one lands badly. Asking your manager is not losing. Said this way, it sounds like you are getting more help for the guest. The word properly promises a better answer, not just another person.

SAY IT Let me get my manager so we can sort this out properly.

Let me get my manager so we can sort this out properly for you.

8. Which one does a senior professional say?

Why the other one lands badly. Put right sounds more professional than fix. Is that okay makes a guest say yes even when they are not happy. This question asks if anything is still wrong.

SAY IT **Is there anything else I can put right for you?**

Is there anything else I can put right for you this evening?

The eight phrases

The same eight lines, now with the pronunciation and the reason each one works. Listen, then say each out loud.

1/8

That should not have happened.

/ðæt ʃʊd nɒt həv 'hæpənd/

AGREEING WITH THE GUEST

INSTEAD OF I am so sorry, I am so sorry.

Why it works. You are agreeing with the guest, not only saying sorry. Saying sorry again and again can sound weak. When you agree, the guest feels you are on their side.

That should not have happened, and I understand why you are upset.

Hindi dapat nangyari iyon.

2/8

Let me see what I can do right now.

/lət mi: si: wɒt aɪ kən du: raɪt naʊ/

SHOWING YOU HAVE STARTED

INSTEAD OF I will try.

Why it works. The important words are right now. I will try sounds like no. When you say right now, the guest knows you have already started, so they stop repeating themselves.

Let me see what I can do right now, Mister Adeyemi.

Tingnan ko po kung ano ang magagawa ko ngayon din.

3/8

I am going to fix this for you tonight.

/aɪ əm 'gəʊɪŋ tu: fiks ðɪs fɔ: ju: tə'naɪt/

MAKING A PROMISE

INSTEAD OF I will try to sort something out.

Why it works. You say who will fix it, and when. I am going to is a promise. I will try is not. Guests ask for a manager when nobody takes the job, so this sentence keeps it with you.

I am going to fix this for you tonight. Give me two minutes.

Aayusin ko po ito para sa inyo ngayong gabi.

4/8

Here is what I can offer you.

/hɪər ɪz wɒt aɪ kən 'ɒfə juː/

MOVING TO THE ANSWER

INSTEAD OF Unfortunately, there is nothing available.

Why it works. Now you move from the problem to the answer. If you begin with unfortunately, the guest waits for bad news. If you begin with here is, they listen.

Here is what I can offer you, and please tell me if it does not work.

Ito po ang maiaalok ko sa inyo.

5/8

I have moved you to a room on the executive floor.

/aɪ hæv muːvd juː tuː ə ruːm ɒn ðɪ ɪg'zɛkjʊtɪv flɔː/

THE FIX, ALREADY DONE

INSTEAD OF I could maybe move you to another room?

Why it works. Say it is done, not that it might happen. A question sounds like you are not sure. I have moved you tells the guest the problem is already finished.

I have moved you to a room on the executive floor at no extra charge.

Inilipat ko na po kayo sa isang kuwarta sa executive floor.

6/8

I will take personal responsibility for this.

/aɪ wɪl teɪk 'pɜːsənəl rɪˌspɒnsə'bɪləti fɔː ðɪs/

CALMING THE GUEST DOWN

INSTEAD OF It was the system, not me.

Why it works. Do not blame the computer. It may be true, but it does not help. The guest wants a person, not a reason. This sentence usually stops a guest asking for a manager.

I will take personal responsibility for this until you are settled.

Personal ko pong pananagutan ito.

7/8

Let me get my manager so we can sort this out properly.

/let miː get maɪ 'mænɪdʒə səʊ wiː kən sɔːt ðɪs aʊt 'prɒpəli/

ASKING FOR HELP

INSTEAD OF I am not allowed to do that.

Why it works. Asking your manager is not losing. Said this way, it sounds like you are getting more help for the guest. The word properly promises a better answer, not just another person.

Let me get my manager so we can sort this out properly for you.

Tatawagin ko po ang manager para maayos ito nang maayos.

8/8

Is there anything else I can put right for you?

/ɪz ðeər 'eniθɪŋ els aɪ kən pʊt raɪt fɔː juː/

CHECKING NOTHING IS LEFT

INSTEAD OF Is that okay?

Why it works. Put right sounds more professional than fix. Is that okay makes a guest say yes even when they are not happy. This question asks if anything is still wrong.

Is there anything else I can put right for you this evening?

Mayroon pa po bang iba na maaayos ko para sa inyo?

The steps

This is the sequence. It does not change.



Agree · Act · Promise · Check

Four steps. If you remember nothing else tonight, remember that order. A guest who feels heard, then helped, then looked after, almost never asks for your manager.

Now you produce it

Write your answer first, then compare. Retrieving the phrase from a situation is what moves it into the language you can actually use under pressure. There is more than one right answer.

1. A guest's confirmed room has been given away. They are furious.

That should not have happened.

You are agreeing with the guest, not only saying sorry. Saying sorry again and again can sound weak. When you agree, the guest feels you are on their side.

2. A guest is repeating the same complaint for the third time.

Let me see what I can do right now.

The important words are right now. I will try sounds like no. When you say right now, the guest knows you have already started, so they stop repeating themselves.

3. A guest wants to know what you are actually going to do about it.

I am going to fix this for you tonight.

You say who will fix it, and when. I am going to is a promise. I will try is not. Guests ask for a manager when nobody takes the job, so this sentence keeps it with you.

4. You have found a solution and need to move the conversation to it.

Here is what I can offer you.

Now you move from the problem to the answer. If you begin with unfortunately, the guest waits for bad news. If you begin with here is, they listen.

5. You have upgraded them. Tell them in a way that closes the issue.

I have moved you to a room on the executive floor.

Say it is done, not that it might happen. A question sounds like you are not sure. I have moved you tells the guest the problem is already finished.

6. The guest is asking for your manager, and you can still handle this.

I will take personal responsibility for this.

Do not blame the computer. It may be true, but it does not help. The guest wants a person, not a reason. This sentence usually stops a guest asking for a manager.

7. You genuinely cannot resolve this at your level.

Let me get my manager so we can sort this out properly.

Asking your manager is not losing. Said this way, it sounds like you are getting more help for the guest. The word properly promises a better answer, not just another person.

8. The guest has calmed down. Make sure nothing is left unresolved.

Is there anything else I can put right for you?

Put right sounds more professional than fix. Is that okay makes a guest say yes even when they are not happy. This question asks if anything is still wrong.

Come back to this

Two situations, on the two days the research says matter. Say the phrase out loud before you look at the list again.

3/day **Day 3**

Three days ago you learned the four steps: agree, act, promise, check. New situation. A guest's luggage has been lost by the airline, not by you, and they are at your desk in tears. Nothing here is your hotel's fault. Which of the four steps still applies, and which sentence would you open with?

7/day **Day 7**

One week in. This is the one people get wrong. A guest is angry about something that is genuinely not your hotel's fault, and they are becoming rude to you personally. Two phrases from this lesson still work here. One of them protects you while still serving the guest. Can you remember which?

NOW YOU HAVE WORKED THROUGH IT

"I know what to say when a guest is furious and asks for my manager."

What you can do now

The same four, to check yourself against.

1. Identify which of two replies a senior professional would give, and say why
2. Explain why apologising twice makes an angry guest angrier, not calmer
3. Produce all eight lines from the situation alone, without reading them
4. Evaluate your own wording mid-complaint and change it before the guest asks for your manager